

21st Annual African Vaccinology Course (AAVC)



Building Vaccinology Expertise for Africa

Cape Town, South Africa



UNIVERSITY OF CAPE TOWN
UNIVERSITEIT YAKESAPA • UNIVERSITEIT VAN KAAPSTAD
HEALTH SCIENCES



Independent Selection Committee – Online Screening & Scoring Manual (2026)

Thank you for accepting the invitation to serve on the Independent Selection Committee for the **21st Annual African Vaccinology Course (AAVC)**. Your thorough and objective evaluation is critical to ensuring a balanced, diverse, and high-calibre participant cohort for this milestone course.

For the 2026 intake, we have transitioned from manual Excel spreadsheets and OneDrive folders to the dedicated **AAVC Database & Online Screening Portal**. This portal centralizes all applications, document links, automated scoring rubrics, and country ranking leaderboards in one secure web platform.

Key Information & Support

- **Screening Timeline:** Please complete all evaluations for your assigned cohorts within the allocated review window.
 - **Support Contacts:** Should you experience any technical issues accessing the portal, opening document links, or questions about selection criteria, please reach out to:
 - **Saleem Satardien:** saleem.satardien@uct.ac.za
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Part 1: How to Log In & Navigate the Portal

1. Portal Access & Initial Login

1. Open the [AAVC Screening Portal](#) URL in your web browser (*Google Chrome, Microsoft Edge, or Safari recommended*).
2. On the white **Alumni & Screener Login card** in the center of your screen, enter your credentials:
 - **Email Address:** Enter your registered email address exactly (e.g., *yournamehereorstudentnumber@uct.ac.za*).
 - **Password:** Your initial login password has been pre-configured to be your **exact email address in all lowercase letters** (e.g., *yournamehereorstudentnumber@uct.ac.za*).
 - *(Note: The portal features smart case-sensitivity handling, so typing your email or password with capital letters will automatically log you in cleanly).*
3. Click the **Red Log In button** located at the bottom of the login card. You will be taken immediately to your personalized **Screening Workspace**.

2. Understanding Your Screening Workspace Layout

Once logged in, your workspace is organized into three main sections:

1. Top Control & View Bar:

- **Select Cohort / Province Dropdown:** Located at the top left next to *Screening Year: AAVC 2026*. Click this dropdown to select the specific country/cohort you want to review (e.g., *Algeria, Nigeria, SA-WC*).
- **Progress Bar:** Displays real-time progress for your selected cohort (e.g., *Progress for Algeria: 0 / 1 Scored*).
- **View Mode Buttons (Top Right):**
 - Review & Score Queue (*Active default view for reviewing individual candidates*)
 - Cohort Ranking Table (*Switch to view the full sorted leaderboard once scoring is done*)
 - Export Cohort Excel (*Export cohort data*)

2. Left Sidebar (**Applicant Queue**):

- Contains a search bar (*Search applicant...*) and a status filter dropdown.

- Lists all applicants belonging to the selected cohort as individual white cards showing their name, institution, and decision status pill (e.g., *PENDING* in yellow).
 - **Clicking any applicant's card on the left sidebar** loads their complete profile and scoring card into the main right window.
3. **Main Right Window (*Application Info, Documents & Scoring*):**
- Displays the selected candidate's full profile cards, uploaded document buttons, and scoring card.
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Part 2: Step-by-Step Screening & Scoring Workflow

Step 1 – Select Applicant & Review Background Info

1. Select your assigned cohort from the **Select Cohort / Province** dropdown at the top.
2. Click an applicant's card on the **left sidebar** to load their file into the main right window.
3. **Review Summary Cards (*Shown Directly on Screen*):** You do not need to open a separate application form file. The candidate's information is displayed directly on the screen across four summary cards:
 - **Demographics & Contact:** DOB, Gender, Nationality, Residence, Mobile.
 - **Professional & Institution:** Current Position, Institution Name & Address, Highest Education.
 - **Vaccinology & NITAG Background:** Shows **Previous AAVC** attendance answer (Yes/No), NITAG membership, English proficiency, and other courses.
 - **Line Manager Information:** Supervisor Name, Email, and Phone Contact.
4. **Outright Rejection Rule (Prior Attendance):** Check the **Previous AAVC** field under *Vaccinology & NITAG Background*. If it is confirmed that the applicant has attended AAVC in person before, scroll down to the bottom scoring card, select **Yes (-1 pt - DQ)** under *Attended AAVC previously?* Set the **Decision** dropdown to **Reject**, enter a comment stating, "Previously attended course", and click the **large red Save & Record Score button**. You do not need to score the remaining criteria. If they have **not** attended in person, proceed to Step 2.

Step 2 – Open & Verify Uploaded Supporting Documents

In the middle section of the main window under **Uploaded Supporting Documents (Click to Open in New Tab)**, click the buttons to open each submitted document in a new browser tab:

- **Open Abridged CV (Inline):** Verify that the CV is **strictly maximum 2 pages**.
- **Open Motivation Letter (Inline):** Verify that the Motivation Letter is **strictly maximum 1 page**.
- **Open HOD Support Letter (Inline):** Verify that the Recommendation/Support Letter is **strictly maximum 1 page**.

Document Length Discretion & Rejection Rule:

- **Within Limits / Slightly Over:** If all three documents are within the required page limits (*use your discretion if a document is just a little over*), proceed with scoring the rest of the application.
- **Excessively Long Documents:** If the documents are excessively long and the rules of document length have not been adhered to, use your discretion score them down for not adhering to guidance as per rubric. Enter a custom comment stating why they were scored down or rejected (e.g., "*CV is over 10 pages; exceeds document length rules*").

Step 3 – Score the Rubric Criteria

Scroll down to the **Scoring Card** at the **bottom of the main window**. Click the round radio buttons to assign points for each criterion based on the official AAVC scoring guidelines. The running total (*Maximum possible: **7 points***) will update automatically:

Rubric Criterion	Point Options & Selection Guidance
1. Attended AAVC Previously?	• No (+1 pt): Candidate has not attended AAVC before. • Yes (-1 pt - Automatic Rejection): Candidate previously attended in person.
2. Current Position & Involvement	• 2 pts: Works directly in human vaccine research or immunization systems. • 1 pt: Works indirectly in human vaccine research (e.g., <i>general health-related or public health field</i>).

Rubric Criterion	Point Options & Selection Guidance
	• 0 pts: Non-human vaccine work (e.g., <i>veterinary vaccines</i>) or non-vaccine work.
3. Curriculum Vitae (CV)	• 1 pt: CV is strictly maximum 2 pages AND clearly demonstrates current involvement or a clear career pathway toward involvement in vaccines/immunization systems. • 0 pts: Exceeds 2 pages OR lacks relevance to vaccines/immunization.
4. Motivation Letter	• 1 pt: Letter is strictly maximum 1 page AND clearly demonstrates strong need for training (<i>capacity to benefit</i>) as well as the ability to contribute during and after AAVC (e.g., <i>transmitting learnings to colleagues/institution</i>). • 0 pts: Exceeds 1 page OR lacks compelling motivation/justification.
5. Recommendation Letter	• 1 pt: Letter is strictly maximum 1 page, ideally from their direct line manager/supervisor, written on official signed letterhead, and strongly recommends the candidate with concrete evidence. • 0 pts: Exceeds 1 page, unofficial/unsigned, or weak support. Note: scrutinize the letter for credibility including positionality of line manager/supervisor, letterhead, signature, date (should be recent, June/July 2026)
6. Completeness & Alignment	• 1 pt: All three required documents (CV, Motivation Letter, Recommendation Letter) are present, complete, and strictly adhere to all page limits. • 0 pts: Any document missing or violating page guidelines.

Step 4 – Select Standardized Comments & Add Notes

Below the rubric criteria on the scoring card, click one or more of the comments in the **Multi-Select Comments Bank** to attach standardized feedback, or type custom notes in the text box labelled “**Additional Custom Comments / Notes:**”

Step 5 – Save Score & Initial Decision (*Crucial Step*)

1. **Assign Decision:** Using the **Decision** dropdown at the bottom of the scoring card, select Accept, Pending / Reserve, or Reject.
 2. Click the **large red Save & Record Score button** at the bottom of the scoring card. This saves your score and evaluation to the database and marks the applicant as scored.
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Part 3: Finalizing Country Rankings & Selection Rules

Once you have evaluated and clicked **Save** for **all applicants within a country cohort**:

1. **Switch to the Leaderboard View:** Click the **Cohort Ranking Table button** located at the top right of the header control bar.
2. **Review the Sorted Leaderboard:** The table displays all applicants in the cohort automatically sorted from highest score to lowest score and by decision priority.
3. **Assign Sequential Ranks:** Input their numerical ranking (1, 2, 3, 4, etc.) into the **Rank in Country** box for each applicant.
 - **CRITICAL: You must rank ALL applicants from the same cohort sequentially (1 to N)**, including rejected or reserve candidates! This numerical ranking allows the committee to immediately extend invitations to the next-highest ranked candidate (#3, #4, etc.) if a top-ranked applicant (#1 or #2) is unable to attend.

Official Acceptance Quotas per Country:

- **Rank #1 Candidate** → (*Prioritized for **In-Person Attendance***).
 - **Rank #2 Candidate** → (*Prioritized for **Online Attendance**, or in-person if the candidate is exceptionally strong and funding permits*).
 - **Rank #3 and lower** → Ensure their numerical rank (3, 4, 5, etc.) is recorded so they can serve as alternates.
 - **Single-Applicant Countries:** If there is only one applicant from an assigned cohort, conduct the full screening process and recommend **Accept** (*Rank 1*) if they meet the criteria, or **Reject** if they do not meet the minimum threshold.
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Thank you once again for your dedication, expertise, and contribution to the Annual African Vaccinology Course!